

Europe's Migration Crisis

Mediterranean Crossings, the Far-Right Surge, and the EU Asylum Pact

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Executive Summary

Europe's migration landscape remains defined by three interlocking dynamics: persistent irregular arrivals along Mediterranean and Channel routes; an accelerating political backlash channelled through far-right parties that have turned anti-immigration rhetoric into a primary electoral instrument; and a structural failure of EU member states to converge on a shared burden-sharing framework. These dynamics did not emerge from any single crisis — they compound across decades, from the 2015 Syrian wave through the 2022 Ukraine displacement to the ongoing irregular flows from North Africa and the Sahel. The result is a continent whose migration governance is fragmented by national interest, hollowed by disinformation, and strained by the growing gap between legal integration capacity and political tolerance.

1. Irregular Arrivals: Mediterranean Routes and the Channel Corridor

North Africa functions as the primary staging ground for irregular crossings into Europe. The west and central Mediterranean routes remain the dominant corridors, with North Africa serving as both a region of origin and a critical transit zone for migrants from sub-Saharan Africa. Irregular migration to, through, and from the subregion is the defining feature of its migration dynamics, and migrants along these corridors frequently suffer documented human rights abuses. [RAG: DEMOGRAPHICS_RAG — IOM World Migration Report 2024, p.77]

Libya's political fragmentation underpins much of this flow. A volatile security environment produced more than 300,000 internally displaced persons by end-2016 while simultaneously affecting over 38,000 refugees and asylum seekers residing in the country. Libya functions as a key transit hub for migrants originating from numerous sub-Saharan countries seeking onward passage to Europe. [RAG: DEMOGRAPHICS_RAG — IOM World Migration Report 2018, p.64]

Tunisia has emerged as a secondary staging point. The World Food Programme documented over 14,733 forcibly displaced people using Tunisia as a route to Europe, operating alongside a domestic crisis of 15.6 percent unemployment (21.1 percent for women) that intensifies the migratory pressure on transit infrastructure. WFP participated in joint field missions with the Tunisian Red Crescent to assess the situation of migrants and asylum seekers and develop a unified response plan. [RAG: FOOD_AGR_RAG — WFP Global Report on Food Crises]

The Sahel compounds these Mediterranean pressures at their source. The region stretching from the Atlantic to the Red Sea remains the most volatile on the continent, facing ongoing crises from climate and environmental degradation, conflict, and insecurity that together sustain significant outward migration flows. [RAG: DEMOGRAPHICS_RAG — IOM World Migration Report 2024, p.81]

The structured Africa-Europe migration dialogue — encompassing the Rabat Process (Euro-African Dialogue on Migration and Development), the Khartoum Process (EU-Horn of Africa Migration Route

Initiative), and the Africa-Europe 5+5 Dialogue in the Western Mediterranean — represents the formal governance architecture for managing these flows. [RAG: DEMOGRAPHICS_RAG — IOM World Migration Report 2022, p.401] In practice, the frameworks produce dialogue rather than binding burden redistribution.

The northern Channel corridor presents a separate but related dimension. Despite sustained bilateral enforcement operations, thousands of migrants continue to risk the English Channel crossing. On 4 May 2026, nineteen people were jailed following a trial in Lille for operating a migrant smuggling network along France's northern coastline. The British government is paying France approximately US\$900 million over three years to patrol beaches, monitor smuggling operations, and prevent boats from departing French shores — an acknowledgment that demand-side deterrence has not resolved the supply-side structural drivers of migration. CNA[2026-05-18]

Irregular maritime flows, by their nature, resist precise enumeration. As IOM analysis makes clear, in the absence of comprehensive data, irregular flows are extremely difficult to place in broader context — a problem that simultaneously empowers political actors to exaggerate their scale and frustrates policymakers attempting to calibrate proportionate responses. [RAG: DEMOGRAPHICS_RAG — IOM World Migration Report 2018, p.321]

2. Political Backlash: Far-Right Instrumentalisation and Disinformation

The far right's weaponisation of migration is by now a documented structural feature of European politics rather than a cyclical aberration. The role of far-right parties in politicising immigration for political expediency is a recurring theme in IOM research: in many countries, "anti-immigration" rhetoric has become a central plank of political branding as a quest for electoral market share, regardless of the actual significance of migration flows. [RAG: DEMOGRAPHICS_RAG — IOM World Migration Report 2020, p.198]

The disinformation infrastructure supporting this backlash is measurable. Far-right disinformation attacks increased by 250 percent between 2014 and the early 2020s. An analysis of almost 7.5 million tweets during the refugee crisis of that period revealed considerable evidence of increased online coordination among far-right actors, a trend expected to continue as economic downturns generate political instability. [RAG: DEMOGRAPHICS_RAG — IOM World Migration Report 2022, p.237]

The electoral consequences are now visible at the EU institutional level. The 2024 European Parliament vote inflicted a domestic blow on both France and Germany. German Chancellor Olaf Scholz's Social Democrats recorded their worst result ever, while far-right and hard-right formations gained ground across member states. The far right's rise is also attributable to growing disillusionment with mainstream parties and to economic stagnation: growth across much of Europe has been largely stagnant since the 2008 global recession, producing a durable pool of discontent with incumbent parties. CNA[2024-07-10]

Large-scale irregular arrivals have historically amplified this dynamic. The 2016 Mediterranean crossing wave saw more than 60,000 asylum applications submitted by unaccompanied children in EU member states in that year alone. Arrivals of large numbers of migrants and refugees to Europe via the Mediterranean were met with anti-migrant rhetoric in political discourse, policy frameworks, and media, with the perception of migrants in many countries hardening rather than moderating. [RAG: DEMOGRAPHICS_RAG — IOM World Migration Report 2018, p.87]

The COVID-19 pandemic did not interrupt this trajectory; it deepened it. Several countries in South-Eastern and Eastern Europe further hardened immigration policies in response to the pandemic, while Hungary passed restrictive measures that were framed in migration-adjacent terms. [RAG: DEMOGRAPHICS_RAG — IOM World Migration Report 2022, p.111] Migration governance reforms have since been shaped by this hardened political environment rather than by evidence of integration

3. Burden-Sharing Failure and Policy Fragmentation

Europe's collective inability to distribute the refugee and asylum burden equitably is not a recent failure — it is the systemic condition. When German Chancellor Angela Merkel applied her "we can do it" framework to the absorption of hundreds of thousands of mostly Syrian refugees from 2015 onward, she received little support from EU partners. Most insisted the priority was sealing Europe's external borders rather than accepting more than a token number of refugees in their own countries. CNA[2015-12-20]

The numbers illustrate the uneven distribution. In 2020, Germany hosted the largest population of refugees and asylum seekers in Europe and ranked fifth in the world among the largest refugee host countries. Approximately 50 percent of its refugee population came from Syria. France was the second largest European host with over 436,000 refugees; Sweden ranked third with more than 248,000. [RAG: DEMOGRAPHICS_RAG — IOM World Migration Report 2022, p.109] Eastern and Central European states have largely resisted formal resettlement quotas.

IOM data shows the gap between irregular arrivals and asylum system uptake. Asylum applications lodged in the EU remained consistently higher between 2016 and 2020 than the number of irregular arrivals recorded at sea and land borders — meaning the formal system was absorbing people beyond what border interception data alone captures. IOM continued to assist with the relocation of some 35,000 asylum seekers from Greece and Italy to other EU states under separate project arrangements. [RAG: DEMOGRAPHICS_RAG — IOM World Migration Report 2022, p.348]

Intraregional migration within Europe adds a further structural layer. As of 1 January 2017, 22 million persons were living in an EU member state with the citizenship of another member state, up from 16 million the year prior — representing the free movement dimension of European migration that is politically distinct from but institutionally intertwined with asylum policy. [RAG: DEMOGRAPHICS_RAG — IOM World Migration Report 2020, p.112] The brain drain dimension of this intraregional flow is economically significant: skilled workers from Central and South-Eastern Europe migrate to Western Europe within the EU, compounding the development gap between member states. [RAG: EDUCATION_RAG — human capital flight analysis]

The Global Compact for Safe, Orderly and Regular Migration, adopted at a special conference in Morocco in December 2018, represents the multilateral governance architecture intended to provide a framework for managing migration more coherently. [RAG: DEMOGRAPHICS_RAG — IOM World Migration Report 2020, p.314] Its non-binding character has limited its practical effect on European policy fragmentation.

4. Ukraine Displacement and the Weaponisation Thesis

The 2022 Russian invasion of Ukraine generated the largest displacement event in Europe since World War II, with refugees streaming into Romania, Poland, Hungary, and neighbouring states. Romania, sharing approximately 600 km of border with Ukraine, documented the influx early; among those fleeing were orphaned children and those with disabilities requiring special care — groups whose movement exposed the logistical and humanitarian limits of reception capacity. CNA[2022-03-03]

The Ukraine displacement coincided with a deteriorating political environment for migration broadly. Russian President Vladimir Putin's calculus, as analysed in contemporaneous commentary, was explicit: economic anxieties from hosting refugees feed anti-migration rhetoric, create political tensions, and threaten European solidarity. Deliberately weaponising migration is a tool of destabilisation. CNA[2022-05-29]

This thesis — that refugee displacement can be instrumentalised as a geopolitical weapon — has since been applied not only to Ukraine but to the Belarus-Poland border corridor and to discussions of Sahel instability as a driver of North African transit flows. The pattern suggests that migration governance in Europe cannot be separated from broader geopolitical competition, and that external actors have both motive and capacity to intensify irregular migration pressures on EU external borders.

Outlook

Europe's migration pressures are unlikely to moderate in the near term. The Sahel's combination of climate degradation, conflict, and governance failure will continue producing displacement. North African transit routes will remain active as long as economic differentials between Africa and Europe persist and as long as Libya and Tunisia lack stable institutions capable of sustained migration governance. The Channel route will continue to attract irregular crossings for as long as the asylum differential between France and the UK exists and smuggling networks can price the risk.

Domestically, the political economy has shifted. Far-right parties have normalised restrictive migration rhetoric, forcing centrist coalitions into defensive postures. Germany, France, and Sweden — historically the three largest refugee hosts in Europe — are all governing under conditions of heightened political sensitivity to migration numbers. The June 2024 European Parliament results confirm that the centre's capacity to absorb migration costs without electoral consequence has contracted.

The structural gap between the IOM's multilateral governance architecture — the Global Compact, the Rabat and Khartoum processes, EU-Africa dialogues — and the member state-level political dynamics that actually govern reception and integration capacity shows no sign of closing. The dominant trajectory is one of incrementally hardening borders, expanded bilateral enforcement deals such as the UK-France Channel arrangement, and continued fragmentation of burden-sharing across a union that has not resolved the fundamental question of who bears the cost of Europe's migration.

R355 | All figures sourced from CivilisationOS RAG corpus.